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Doctors and medicine

1.15 Doctors and medicine

Oil, ointment

1.15.1 Oil, ointment

References:

Hebrew שֶׁמֶן (shemen) ISA 1:6

Greek ἔλαιον (elaion) MRK 6:13, LUK 10:34, JAS 5:14

Description:

Ointment was oil extracted from the fruit of olive trees.

Usage:

The oil itself served to soothe and to soften wounds. It could also serve as a base to which other medicinal plant extracts were added. See also 1.10.5 Anointing oil<REALIA:1.10.5> and 9.3 Olive oil<REALIA:9.3>.

Translation:

In LUK 10:34 it is important to recognize the medicinal value of oil and wine. In some instances translators have indicated the purpose of such an activity by translating “He went over to him. To cleanse and heal his wounds, he poured wine and oil on them and bandaged them ….” It may also be helpful to add a marginal note to explain the antiseptic quality of wine and the value of oil in the healing process.

Some have questioned whether the anointing with oil in JAS 5:14 is primarily a medicinal act or a spiritual one. A Handbook on The Letter from James says the following concerning this: “As to the function of **anointing**, it is well known that olive oil was often used in the ancient world for medical purposes; for example, in cleansing, soothing, and healing wounds (2KI 20:7; ISA 1:6; MRK 6:13; LUK 10:34). While not ruling out the possibility that the anointing here is for medical purposes, there are certainly other factors involved. Most probably it also has religious and symbolic purposes, reminding the sick person of God’s concern for his faithful people in time of distress, and stimulating as well as awakening faith. This is confirmed by the fact that the anointing is performed **in the name of the Lord**. In any case these interpretations will not in any way affect the outcome of translation” (page 190).

Poultice, fig cake

1.15.2 Poultice, fig cake

References:

Hebrew דְּבֵלָה, תְּאֵנָה (dveleth t’enim) 2KI 20:7, ISA 38:21

Greek μάλαγμα (malagma) WIS 16:12

Description:

The poultice was a lump or pressed block of dried figs.

Usage:

Such a block of dried figs could be used simply as food (see 9.5 Blocks of pressed dried fruit<REALIA:9.5>). The dried fruit would keep for a long time. On occasion it could be applied to a boil or eruption on the skin as a means of softening the skin for healing.

Translation:

In the story of the healing of Hezekiah (2KI 20:7; ISA 38:21), the exact nature of the fig application is uncertain. Several models for translating the Hebrew phrase dveleth t’enim are “mashed figs” (CEV), “paste of crushed

figs" (FRCL), "fig-plaster" (REB), and "paste made of figs" (GNT). Where figs are unknown, translators may say "fruit named fig" or find some local fruit that could serve both as food and medicine.

The Greek word malagma in WIS 16:12 refers to a kind of compress that was intended to soften a wound or sore on the skin. The word "ointment" in GNT and TOB is somewhat imprecise, while the word "poultice" (RSV) is obscure in English. NAB says "application," which is a useful model. ITCL has "bandage."

Eye salve

1.15.3 Eye salve

Reference:

Greek κολλούριον (kollourion) REV 3:18

Description:

Eye salve was an ointment. It is possible that it was also in the form of a powder.

Usage:

The salve was applied to the eyes as a medicine.

Translation:

Where the equivalent for a specific "eye salve/ointment/ paste" is not available, the Greek word kollourion may be rendered simply as "medicine for the eyes."

Bandage

1.15.4 Bandage

References:

Hebrew אֵפֶר (ʾafer) 1KI 20:38, 1KI 20:41

Hebrew חִתּוּל (chitul) EZK 30:21

Greek καταδέω (katadeō (verb)) SIR 27:21

Description and usage:

The bandage was a strip of cloth used to wind around a broken arm or leg while it healed.

Translation:

Most languages will have a word for a bandage or binding for a broken limb. The modern word for a hard plaster cast would be an anachronism and should be avoided. In EZK 30:21 the Hebrew word chitul means strictly something that is wound around the broken arm and not a sling in which the arm rests. However, the poetic language of the verse repeats the description and thus makes it possible to expand the translation; for example, the last half of this verse in GNT reads "No one bandaged it or put it in a sling so that it could heal and be strong enough to hold a sword again" (similarly CEV).

Drugged wine, myrrhed wine

1.15.5 Drugged wine, myrrhed wine

Reference:

Greek σμυρνίζω, οἶνος (esmurnismenos oinos) MRK 15:23

Description:

Drugged wine was wine mixed with myrrh. It was used as a potion to reduce pain.

Translation:

In general the Greek phrase esmurnismenos oinos must be rendered by means of a phrase or clause, for example, “wine that has been mixed with a drug called myrrh” or “wine mixed with a drug to reduce pain.” It is also possible to use an abbreviated phrase such as “myrrhed wine” and then to place the explanation of its function in a footnote.